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- CM's chief principal secretary K.M. Abraham faces a disproportionate assets probe
- Kerala HC says there is "prima facie evidence" to merit a probe
- In 2016, Abraham had got a clean chit from the state vigilance department in the case

- CM Pinarayi is in some bother with an SFIO case against his daughter Veena Thaikkandiyil, involving fraudulent payments to her IT firm
- Kerala faces an assembly election in early 2026, and Pinarayi, looking for a third term on the trot for him and the CPI(M), can ill afford the controversies

be worth Rs 3 crore, and a shopping complex in Kollam, Kerala, said to be worth Rs 8 crore.

The state vigilance department had investigated the same case and given Abraham a clean chit in 2016. Their report says that the IAS officer took the flat in Thiruvananthapuram in 2002 by paying Rs 13.5 lakh in instalments; purchased the Mumbai flat for Rs 1 crore with a loan from the State Bank of India in 2009; and that the shopping complex was jointly owned with his two NRI brothers, and was built for Rs 2.5 crore. The vigilance department had fixed the 'check period' for Abraham's assets from Jan. 1, 2000 to Dec. 31, 2009, but the HC calls that a "farce". It wants the check period to be from Jan. 1, 2003 to Dec. 31, 2015.

Meanwhile, Abraham has met the CM and offered to quit his posts. He has also written to him, implicating two people, a trade union leader and a former civil servant who served during the Congress government (2011-16), saying they were behind the conspiracy along with the petitioner. Their phone conversations, sourced by the vigilance department during its probe, were listed to prove his point. Fingers have also been pointed at ex-DGP Jacob Thomas (who's now with the BJP), saying he was in league with the petitioner. Abraham is moving a special leave petition in the Supreme Court against the HC order.

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>
> **K.M. ABRAHAM**
> Chief Principal Secretary, CMO, Kerala

The former IAS officer also has friends batting for him. "I have known Abraham for a long time," says Sheela Thomas, a retired additional chief secretary and now MD of the Kottayam-based Hindustan Newsprint Ltd. "He is an officer with high integrity and, unlike many others, someone who does not yield to pressure from corrupt people. It's most unfortunate that he's being investigated in such a case."

Abraham says he "welcomes the probe by CBI or any other agency". He points to how after the Sahara Parivar indictment in 2009, the CBI and I-T department had looked into his assets and even verified family members' banking transactions. He claims they had not found any discrepancies in the accounts then. "I've listed all my income and submitted records. Now, it's my 43rd year in public service and I don't mind another scrutiny," the 66-year-old told INDIA TODAY.

For CM Pinarayi, the Abraham case must bring a strong sense of déjà vu. A year before the 2020 assembly election, the Kerala CM had been battling the gold smuggling allegations against Sivasankar. And now with the 79-year-old chasing a historic third term in 2026, there is not just the Abraham case but also a Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) probe against his own daughter, Veena Thaikkandiyil. The MD of Exalogic Solutions Pvt Ltd, a Bengaluru-based IT services provider, she is accused of receiving Rs 2.7 crore from the Kochi centred Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd without offering any services. The high court has ordered status quo for two months on a sessions court ruling taking cognisance of a complaint in which Veena and 12 others are accused. The SFIO has charged her under Section 447 of the Companies Act which deals with punishment for fraud, with stringent penalties, including jail, for up to 10 years.

Legal circles are of the view that unlike the charges against Veena, the CBI probe against Abraham is a ploy to attract Enforcement Directorate (ED) action and get the Kerala CM embroiled in an investigation by the time the state election rolls up in early 2026. Pinarayi is no stranger to such tactics, but how he tackles the latest mess will also affect the future of his party, the CPI(M), which can ill afford to slip up in the only state where it is in power. ■